astronaut Kalpana Chawla, singer Lata Mangeshkar and corporate chieftains like former Pepsi Chairman and CEO Indira Nooyi and Biocon's Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw. It also has sections on the contributions of women as mothers, wives, housewives, protectors of culture and tradition that sit side-by-side with their contributions as scientists, politicians and administrators. While the BJP stresses on the equality of women, it regards the traditional feminist movement as an imported 'Western' concept.[146] This is an important distinction.

Citing ancient Vedic sages like Gargi, Kapila, Arundhati and Maitreyi as examples of women's agency in ancient India, the BJP argues that the historical contexts of women's movements in the West and India are different. 'In the Western view, woman was regarded as lower,' says the training manual. Speaking of Christian traditions, it argues that 'her Creation was from Adam's ribs and so she is a sub-part and her work is to keep man happy and serve him'. Many Western women's rights movements initially had to fight for their rights 'first from religion and the Church and then from the sovereign and the State'. This is why, in the BJP's view, their 'practices cannot be replicated to solve the problems of Indian women because India's intellectual, historical context and way of thinking towards women is different'. Acknowledging that, over several centuries, 'some bad customs were born', the BJP sees the degradation of the status of women in India as the result of centuries of political instability. Working women in India, it argues, are only regaining 'their ancient respected status', and bringing 'bad customs' to an end. 'They [women] don't need to fight with Dharmashastra [religious text] or to be freed from anyone,' says the BJP. In this view, women need equality and 'shakti' (power), not 'mukti' (emancipation).[147]

The RSS agrees with this critique of Western as well as traditional Indian feminism that defines women's empowerment in terms of sexual politics and the philosophy of power. The Sangh's critique of feminism is best encapsulated by ABVP's Sunil Ambedar:[148]

For them [Western feminists], the nature-defined role of women as mothers and carers was a model of femininity based on a patriarchal